

Psalms 55

Cast Thy Burden Upon the Lord

Cast thy burden upon the LORD, and he shall sustain thee
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Give ear to my prayer, O God; and hide not thyself from my supplication.
- 2 Attend unto me, and hear me: I mourn in my complaint, and make a noise;
- 3 Because of the voice of the enemy, because of the oppression of the wicked: for they cast iniquity upon me, and in wrath they hate me.
- 4 My heart is sore pained within me: and the terrors of death are fallen upon me.
- 5 Fearfulness and trembling are come upon me, and horror hath overwhelmed me.
- 6 And I said, Oh that I had wings like a dove! for then would I fly away, and be at rest.
- 7 Lo, then would I wander far off, and remain in the wilderness. Selah.
- 8 I would hasten my escape from the windy storm and tempest.
- 9 Destroy, O Lord, and divide their tongues: for I have seen violence and strife in the city.
- 10 Day and night they go about it upon the walls thereof: mischief also and sorrow are in the midst of it.
- 11 Wickedness is in the midst thereof: deceit and guile depart not from her streets.
- 12 For it was not an enemy that reproached me; then I could have borne it: neither was it he that hated me that did magnify himself against me; then I would have hid myself from him:
- 13 But it was thou, a man mine equal, my guide, and mine acquaintance.
- 14 We took sweet counsel together, and walked unto the house of God in company.
- 15 Let death seize upon them, and let them go down quick into hell: for wickedness is in their dwellings, and among them.
- 16 As for me, I will call upon God; and the LORD shall save me.
- 17 Evening, and morning, and at noon, will I pray, and cry aloud: and he shall hear my voice.
- 18 He hath delivered my soul in peace from the battle that was against me: for there were many with me.
- 19 God shall hear, and afflict them, even he that abideth of old. Selah. Because they have no changes, therefore they fear not God.
- 20 He hath put forth his hands against such as be at peace with him: he hath broken his covenant.
- 21 The words of his mouth were smoother than butter, but war was in his heart: his words were softer than oil, yet were they drawn swords.
- 22 Cast thy burden upon the LORD, and he shall sustain thee: he shall never suffer the righteous to be moved.
- 23 But thou, O God, shalt bring them down into the pit of destruction: bloody and deceitful men shall not live out half their days; but I will trust in thee.

2 · CONTEXT

A psalm of David in deep personal anguish, made worse because the chief enemy is "mine own familiar friend" who broke covenant (traditionally linked with Absalom's revolt and the betrayal of a trusted counselor). Henry notes the psalm's rare emotional intensity—longing to flee like a dove—and its turn from horror at betrayal to settled trust. MacArthur-style notes flag verses 12–14 as an Old Testament anticipation of the pain of intimate betrayal, later echoed in Christ's own experience with Judas.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

"Attend unto me, and hear me: I mourn in my complaint... for the voice of the enemy, because of the oppression of the wicked." David's distraction and anguish are given full voice; he does not suppress the pain of being cast down under enemy pressure.

Verse 4-8

"My heart is sore pained within me... fearfulness and trembling are come upon me... Oh that I had wings like a dove! for then would I fly away, and be at rest." The longing to escape entirely into the wilderness shows how crushing this pressure has become—an honest, almost desperate wish for relief.

Verse 9-11

He prays for the destruction and confusion of his enemies ("destroy... divide their tongues") and describes the city itself as full of violence, strife, deceit, and mischief within its own walls—corruption has infected the whole community, not just isolated enemies.

Verse 12-14

The sharpest wound: "It was not an enemy that reproached me... but it was thou, a man mine equal, my guide, and mine acquaintance... We took sweet counsel together." Betrayal by an intimate friend cuts deeper than open hostility ever could.

Verse 15-19

David prays that death seize such betrayers, "for wickedness is in their dwellings," while he himself will call upon God and be saved—praying "evening, and morning, and at noon," confident that "the Lord shall hear my voice."

Verse 20-23

The friend "hath put forth his hands against such as be at peace with him," his words smoother than oil yet war in his heart. The psalm's climax: "Cast thy burden upon the LORD, and he shall sustain thee: he shall never suffer the righteous to be moved." Bloody and deceitful men will not live out half their days, but David closes, "I will trust in thee."

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Betrayal by a trusted intimate produces a uniquely crushing grief that Scripture does not minimize; yet the psalm's resolution is not escape (the dove's wings) but transferring the crushing weight onto the Lord, who sustains and will not let the righteous be permanently moved.

Application for life today.

When a close friend, colleague, or family member betrays trust, let this psalm validate that the pain is uniquely severe—do not feel guilty for how deeply it hurts. Resist the temptation to either flee everything or take personal vengeance; instead literally "cast" the burden—name it in prayer and release management of the outcome to God. Build a rhythm of prayer ("evening, and morning, and at noon") especially through seasons of relational betrayal.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

- 1.** Have you experienced the specific pain of verses 12–14—betrayal by "mine own familiar friend"—and how did you respond?
- 2.** What burden do you need to consciously "cast... upon the LORD" today rather than keep carrying?
- 3.** How could praying at set times (morning, noon, evening) help you through a current season of hurt?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).